The Blackout-Proof Home Checklist

Print it. Stick it on the fridge. The middle of an outage is the worst time to figure out what you forgot.

1. Before the power goes out

- [ ] Lights that don't need flames: LED lantern or flashlight per person, plus spare batteries.
- [ ] Phones and power banks charged. Cables in one drawer, not scattered.
- [ ] Appliance thermometer in the fridge AND the freezer (food is safe at or below 40°F).
- [ ] Freezer full or packed with water bottles and ice packs: a full freezer holds temperature longer.
- [ ] Water: about 1 gallon per person per day, enough for at least 3 days.
- [ ] First aid kit and a 7-day supply of any prescription medicines.
- [ ] Battery or crank radio, manual can opener, some cash, a full-ish gas tank in the car.
- [ ] Carbon monoxide alarm with battery backup in the hall near bedrooms. Test it today.
- [ ] Write down the running watts of any medical device (CPAP, oxygen concentrator) and how many hours it must run.
- [ ] Find the data plate on your freezer and fridge. Write down the LRA number: it is the surge your battery must survive.

2. During the outage: the rules that matter

- [ ] Keep fridge and freezer doors CLOSED. A closed fridge stays safe about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours, a half-full one about 24.
- [ ] Never run a gas generator, grill or camp stove indoors, in a garage, or near a window or vent.
- [ ] Never plug a generator or power station into a wall outlet to power the house (backfeeding can kill utility workers).
- [ ] Don't heat the house with a gas oven or stove. Use layers, blankets and one warm room.
- [ ] Use LED lanterns instead of candles. If you must use a candle, one at a time, on a stable surface, never left alone.
- [ ] When in doubt, throw it out. Never taste food to check it, because contamination often has no smell or taste.

3. When the power comes back

- [ ] Check the thermometer before eating anything cold. Above 40°F for more than a couple of hours means discard.
- [ ] Wait a few minutes before plugging big loads back in so they don't all start at once.
- [ ] Recharge every battery, restock water and batteries, and note what you ran short of.

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The watt math nobody explains: how long a battery really runs your stuff

The one formula

Runtime (hours) = usable Wh ÷ average watts

Usable Wh is about 85% of the rated Wh (inverter losses). A 1,070Wh unit gives about 910Wh.
Example: 910Wh ÷ 45W (a typical chest freezer's average draw) = about 20 hours.

What common loads draw (1,000Wh-class battery, about 850Wh usable)

Device	Running watts	Roughly runs for
LED light bulb	10W	about 85 hours
Wi-Fi router	10W	about 85 hours
Phone charger	18W	about 47 hours
Laptop	45W	about 19 hours
CPAP (no heated humidifier)	30W	about 28 hours
CPAP (heated humidifier)	60W	about 14 hours
Refrigerator (average draw)	about 60W	about 14 hours
Chest freezer, 7 cu ft (average draw)	about 45W	about 19 hours
Window AC, 5,000 BTU (with cycling)	350-500W	about 2 to 4 hours

Averages, not guarantees. Fridges and freezers cycle on and off, so measure yours with a plug-in watt meter.

Which size battery? Match it to the job

- ☐ About 270Wh: phones, router, lights, and a CPAP for a night or two.
- ☐ About 1,000Wh: a fridge for roughly half a day, plus small loads. Good for a short outage.
- ☐ About 2,000Wh and up: fridge plus freezer and lights for about a day, and longer with solar panels.
- ☐ Check SURGE, not just capacity. A freezer or fridge can need 600 to 1,800 watts for a split second to start.

Read more, with the math shown

Chest freezer watts by size	ecoliving-journey.com/blog/how-many-watts-chest-freezer/
What's safe in the fridge without power	ecoliving-journey.com/blog/how-long-food-last-fridge-power-outage/
72-hour power outage guide	ecoliving-journey.com/blog/72-hour-power-outage-survival-guide/
What a solar generator can run	ecoliving-journey.com/blog/what-appliances-can-solar-generator-run/

General preparedness information from published sources, not medical or professional advice. If you rely on a medical device, confirm its power needs and backup plan with your doctor or supplier.